RELEASE NOTES: 2018 SIPP

Revision History		
Date	**Change**	**Updated by**
8/18/20	Initial version	S. Irving
7/24/25	Updated version	J. Lee

Version 1.1 (Released 7/24/25)

On July 24, 2025, the U.S. Census Bureau released updated public-use files for the Survey of Income and Program Participation (SIPP) from 2014 through 2021.

Social Security Amount Correction

From 2014 through 2021, a processing error affected the creation of the monthly Social Security amount variable (TSSSAMT). The SIPP instrument asks about monthly Social Security payments before any Medicare deductions are taken out (gross amounts). However, a processing error added the values of Medicare Parts B, C, and D deductions (ESSPARTBKNOW, TSSPARTCAMT, and TSSPARTDAMT) to the initial Social Security reported amounts, meaning these deductions were double-counted. As a result, values of TSSSAMT were higher than they should have been. This error had downstream effects on income and poverty recodes. This issue was resolved in the 2022 SIPP.

To correct this issue, the Census Bureau removed the double-counting of the value of Medicare deductions.[1] It then re-applied disclosure avoidance procedures to the revised TSSSAMT variable and recreated the personal, family, and household income and poverty recode variables that depend on TSSSAMT as an input. For the 2014 files, these updates also included updating the disclosure avoidance procedure used on TSSSAMT to match the procedure used on subsequent SIPP files.

Minor Changes to the Income Recode Variables

The following minor errors were also corrected in the updated files:

- In the 2018-2020 SIPP, the Type 2 income of unrelated household members was missing in the calculation of total household income including Type 2 persons (THTOTINCT2).[2]
- In the 2014 Panel, total personal income (TPTOTINC) was equal to 0 rather than missing for those who were out of universe (e.g. children under age 15 who did not receive SSI payments).[3]

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[1] Information regarding how to address the processing error in already downloaded data is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2022-usernotes/2022-prior-process-err-affct-soc-sec-self-amts.html>.

[2] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2020-usernotes/2020-thtotinct2-missing.html>.

[3] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2014-w4-usernotes/2014w4-tptotinc-aftotinc-ahtotinc-aftotinct2-errors.html>.

- In the 2014 Panel, the status flags for total family income (AFTOTINC), total household income (AHTOTINC), and total family income including Type 2 persons (AFTOTINCT2) sometimes had a value of 0 (not in universe) or 8 (imputed using a combination of methods) rather than a value of 9 (recoded using other variables).[4]
- In the 2014 Panel, there were some instances in which total family income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2) was calculated incorrectly due to improper treatment of Type 2 income.[5]

There were some additional minor changes implemented in the 2014 panel to align the calculation of total family income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2) and total household income including Type 2 persons (THTOTINCT2) with the 2018 SIPP. The changes include:

- In the calculation of total family income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2),
    - Families are now consistently grouped by Type 2 family number (RFAMNUMT2) in all years.
    - Households are now only grouped by residence (ERESIDENCEID) in all years.
- Type 2 income is no longer rounded before being added to total family/household income including Type 2 persons (TFTOTINCT2/THTOTINCT2).
- Status flag values for total family/household income including Type 2 persons (AFTOTINCT2/AHTOTINCT2) now allow for a value of 3, which indicates the value was logically assigned for cases in which total family/household income comprises only Type 2 income.

Effect on the Poverty Recode Variables

More information about the effects of the Social Security amount correction on poverty can be found in the user note titled 2022 SIPP: Social Security Processing Error and Its Impact on Poverty Estimates. Updated annual and monthly poverty rates using a post-hoc correction that approximates the changes made in the updated files can be found in the tables titled Corrected Annual and Monthly SIPP Poverty Rates: 2014-2022.

Version 1.0 (Released 08/18/20)

The U.S. Census Bureau released public-use data from the 2018 Survey of Income and Program Participation (2018 SIPP). The 2018 SIPP includes Wave 1 of SIPP's 2018 Panel. The data are available in STATA, SAS, and pipe-delimited CSV format.

The SIPP provides comprehensive information about the income and program participation of individuals and households in the United States. The survey collects data and measures change for many topics, including economic well-being, family dynamics, education, assets, health insurance, child care, and food security. SIPP is a longitudinal survey, following the same set of respondents over a four-year period, allowing researchers to understand how these contexts

[4] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2014-w4-usernotes/2014w4-tptotinc-aftotinc-ahtotinc-aftotinct2-errors.html>.
[5] More information about this error is available at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/tech-documentation/user-notes/2014-usernotes/2014-w1-processing-error-fam-inc.html>.

change over time.

Accompanying the data release are a number of supporting materials to assist data users:

(1) Metadata and a data dictionary describing all variables on the 2018 dataset
(2) An updated Users' Guide to assist data users and provide background on the survey
(3) User notes describing nuances with the data and other data issues to be aware of
(4) Crosswalks that map 2018 SIPP variables to their analogues in the 2014 Panel, and vice versa

These materials are available on the SIPP website at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp.html>, as is other information about the survey and a link to download the data. Additional announcements, including notifications of version updates, will be made as necessary through the SIPP website and the SIPP email notification system. To be added to the SIPP email notification system, visit the "Contact Us" page on the SIPP website at <https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/sipp/contact.html>.